

Advanced & Global Techniques

Thailand's assisted stretching, Japan's Shiatsu, Hawaii's Lomi Lomi, and Sweden's foundational strokes — taught with reverence

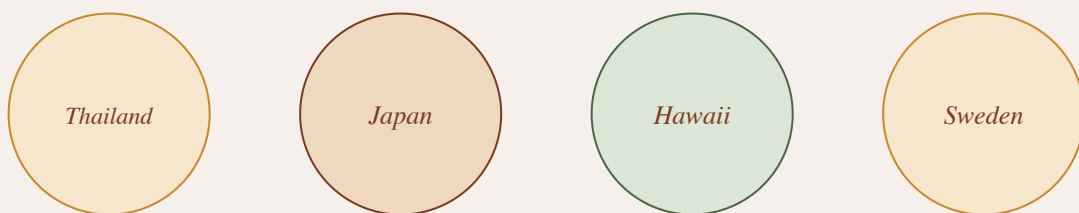
Learning Objectives

- Perform basic Thai massage assisted stretches
- Perform basic Shiatsu pressure-point technique
- Perform the flowing forearm strokes of Lomi Lomi
- Perform the classic strokes of Swedish massage

Four traditions, each with its own name and history

As in every global techniques module across this Atelier, this one teaches four distinct massage traditions individually, rather than blending them into a single generic "relaxation massage" service.

◆ Figure 12.1 · Four Global Traditions



Four distinct traditions, each with its own history and its own name.

Thailand · Assisted stretching

Traditional Thai massage is performed fully clothed on a floor mat, with no oil, combining rhythmic palm and thumb compression along the body's traditional energy lines (*sen*) with assisted, yoga-like stretching guided by the practitioner's hands, knees, and body weight. It demands close attunement to a client's flexibility limits — never forcing a stretch past comfortable resistance, echoing Module Six's core philosophy in an entirely different technical form.

Japan · Shiatsu

Shiatsu ("finger pressure") applies sustained, rhythmic pressure with the fingers, thumbs, and palms along the body's traditional meridian lines, performed through light clothing rather than on bare, oiled skin. Pressure is typically held steadily rather than moved in the gliding strokes of Western massage, working with the body's own breathing rhythm.

Hawaii · Lomi Lomi

Lomi Lomi — often translated as "loving hands" — uses long, flowing strokes performed with the forearms as much as the hands, moving continuously across large areas of the body in a rhythm traditionally described as mirroring ocean waves. Rooted in Hawaiian holistic tradition, it is performed with a philosophy of unbroken, continuous contact and intention, distinct from the more segmented, stop-start structure of many Western massage styles.

Sweden · The foundational Western strokes

Swedish massage, developed in nineteenth-century Sweden, established the core stroke vocabulary underlying most Western spa menus: *effleurage* (long, gliding strokes for warming and connecting), *petrissage* (kneading and lifting muscle tissue), *friction* (small, deep circular pressure), and *tapotement* (rhythmic tapping or percussion). This is the technical foundation the full-body sequence in Module Eleven draws from most directly.

The discipline beneath all four

Each tradition solves for something specific — flexibility and energy-line work in Thailand, sustained meridian pressure in Japan, continuous flowing rhythm in Hawaii, structured stroke vocabulary in Sweden. Teach each by its correct name and origin. A Thai-influenced stretch taught as generic "flexibility work," or Lomi Lomi taught as unlabelled "flowing massage," erases the specific tradition and history a client may be asking for by name.

Key Terms

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Practical Activity · The Four Traditions Portfolio

Perform at least two of the four techniques taught in this module on a partner or model, and research (with proper attribution) the other two well enough to explain their history and technique aloud. **Note your two practiced techniques for your capstone portfolio.**